‘He says: he’s at a birthday party for one of the club’s directors. We could all go round there. It’s not far.’

Senor Valdano was still standing through most of this, waiting to finish. Just as he got round to sitting back down, the President got round to saying goodbye. He hoped we’d enjoy the evening. Everyone at the table turned back towards Senor Valdano, ready for his punchline. I didn’t need to hear any more: I’d already taken in what he’d said so far and felt honored enough. He stood up again. You could see him thinking about where to pick up his thread. And then deciding he needn’t bother. He laughed. His moment had slipped away too. He risked a little English:

‘David and Victoria: welcome to Madrid.’

I really felt we were.

There was still time in the evening for me and Victoria to be rushed off to look at two more houses. I found myself wondering: *When do they sleep in Madrid?* Tuesday had been all about taking care of business, the private side of me joining Real Madrid. Wednesday’s promise was to present a new signing to the world. Brooklyn made his mind up early: other kids, a swimming pool and a back garden, thanks. He and Mum headed off to the house of the parents of someone we’d met the day before. I had two interviews to do: MUTV were in Madrid to give me the chance to say goodbye and thank you to the United supporters; then Real Madrid’s television channel wanted to get my first impressions and, also, my reaction to Roberto Carlos’ statement of delight that, at long last, there’d be two good-looking players at the Bernabeu. Those two interviews, one after the other, were a bittersweet way to spend the morning. It was all very well me finding my answers. Really, I wanted to be asking the questions. I couldn’t help but wonder what fans in Madrid and Manchester thought of how things had turned out.

Real decided on a basketball arena as the venue for my introduction to the media and the fans long before I’d decided on squad number 23. The Pabellon Raimundo Saporta is an enormous, gloomy hangar of a place with a 5,000-seat capacity, part of a training complex they call the Ciudad Deportiva. Our cars screeched in off the main road and swept up a curving drive to the front entrance. There were dozens of journalists waiting outside, and over to my left I glimpsed the field where I’d get the chance to kick a ball, a Real player now, in front of Real supporters for the first time. We hurried inside. I know the Spanish are supposed to have a pretty laid back attitude to their